

making a home by propping up bamboo stems on a barren road, looking like refugees in a war-torn country.

Everyone I met or saw was in pain, each having lost 'someone or something'. Their plight was a challenge to my descriptive powers. I lost hands down. We visited the flood zone, almost a fortnight after the Kosi had breached its embankment and raged over three million people in Bihar. Even then the state machinery, rather the lack of it, was conspicuous by its absence. The white-collar callousness of some officials magnified nature's cruelty, besides showing the Government's wishful ignorance about the disaster. The politicians, however, were much worse. I came across a BJP politician walking a few metres into the flood water for the shutterbugs before returning to his air-conditioned vehicle.

My second visit to the flood-affected zone was 100 days after the embankment breach. Having attended Chief Minister Nitish Kumar's press conference where he underlined the Government's exemplary efforts to help the victims, what I saw shocked me. People were still homeless, most with just a plastic sheet as roofing.

RAVI S. SAHANI



SEEKING COVER

People move their animals and belongings to safer areas after the Kosi breached its embankment on the Nepal border

Houses were broken, fields swamped, a boat mishap every fortnight and land erosion eating up dwellings. Worse still, the chilly winds of winter now cut through the victims' huts, chilling them to

the bone. The state Government has closed down most relief camps, saying people want to return home—a claim that appeared ridiculous when I visited the flood zone.

During my first visit, what moved me was the sight of a silently sobbing father trying to convince his four-year-old son to "sleep on an empty stomach today and that he would bring a jalebi tomorrow".

I have become a father this year. I also am a son. I don't wish to go to that place again.

Keeping Pace with Destiny's Child

By Priya Sahgal

If you are a reporter on the Rahul Gandhi campaign trail, wear comfortable shoes and prepare for an extensive game of hide and seek as he scours the countryside looking for meaningful moments with the world outside 12, Tughlak Lane.

Of course his quest for such moments does not include the media. He regards reporters as an unnecessary intrusion. The gun-toting men in safari suits around him agree and ensure that the media is kept a shouting distance away. Any hopes of an exclusive are dashed by sheer logistics. But there is always a press conference at the end of each tour. The Gandhi scion strolls in with glib one-liners. In Chhattisgarh, having had the media chase him for three days without offering a single soundbyte, he asked politely, "You look very tired. Is the heat getting to you?" On another tour, he walked into a coffee shop for a breakfast interaction and the first thing he looked for was, well breakfast!

His speeches barely last five minutes and he always evokes his lineage. With time he has learnt to be more contemporary and bring up the employment guarantee Act. And there will always be some coy girl sighing over his dimples. That completes the Rahul Gandhi experience. I tend to work the campaign trail much like a commando, looking for the best spot to ambush him as he rushes from the dais to his car to the helipad. My closest observation point was during a late night road show as I ran alongside his Toyota Land Cruiser, driven by a sympathetic Captain Satish Sharma who offered me a Diet Coke. The young dynast figured that I would be too much out of breath to conduct an extensive interview and gave me the SPG clearance. So if you're following RG, the first stop has to be the local gym.



BACK TO BASICS
Rahul Gandhi during the election campaign for the Delhi Assembly polls in 2008

SIPRA DAS